

PAVING THE WAY Tarun Wig, Madhav Krishna, Pranav Vempati, Navya Naveli Nanda, Bodhisattwa Sanghapriya, Raj Chengappa, Genelia Deshmukh, Mona Singh, Jishnu Dev Varma, Nalinikanth Gollagunta, Mehtab Ali Niazi, Radhika Gupta, Sarah Sham, Niraj Rahmohan, Narayan Subramaniam

Vempati, CEO of Makers Hive, a bionic startup that has developed KalArm. One of the world's cheapest bionic hands, as well as India's first, it costs a tenth of the $43,000-$64,000 (Rs 40-60 lakh) that it costs abroad. A beneficiary who lost his hand as a schoolboy and was once dependent on his mother and on a government pension, but now drives his bike to office and supports his own family, demonstrated the use of the assisted device on stage.

Bodhisattwa Sanghapriya, another awardee, was recognised for contributions to military technology. He is the founder and CEO of IG Defence, a company specialising in unmanned strike systems and kamikaze drones. He emphasised that low-cost, agile and mass-scale drones, as well as electronic warfare measures, are reshaping battlefields. Tarun Wig, CEO and co-founder of Innefu Labs, was honoured for similar achievements. He has worked on AI-driven security systems for the army and said that India's eastern border could be guarded entirely by humanoids within the next five years.



JISHNU DEV VARMA
Governor of Maharashtra

"We are awarding 17 remarkable young founders who have transformed their ideas into extraordinary enterprises"

Sarah Sham, principal designer of interior design firm Essajees Atelier, was also felicitated; she stressed that her ambitions weren't limited to being the best in India. "I want to be the best design studio, full stop," she said.

The awardees have made a genuine "difference to people's lives," said Rajesh Jejurikar, executive director and CEO of Mahindra & Mahindra's auto and farm sector division. They are not just building companies but "institutions that we will look back on years from now", said Nalinikanth Gollagunta, CEO of the automotive division. The award has been "a journey to discover the people who are consistently shaping the nation's future," said Neha Anand, vice-president and head of the XUV brand portfolio and international marketing division. "What makes this journey truly unique is how we do it," said Yogendra Pratap, editor, AUTO TODAY. "We do not wait for these stories to come to us, we go to where these stories are." ■